MINUTES OF THE CLARE COUNTY BOARD OF COMMISSIONERS COMMITTEE OF THE WHOLE

Approved 12-18-2024

225 W. Main St.
Harrison, Michigan 48625

~~Unapproved~~ minutes
November 6, 2024

Meeting was called to order at 9:00 a.m.

Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America

District 1 Marlene Housler, District 3 Samantha Pitchford, District 4 Jeff Haskell, District 5 David Hoefling, District 7 Gabe Ambrozaitis, District 8 George Gilmore and District 9 Rick Fancon

COMMISSIONERS ABSENT

District 2 Dale Majewski and District 6 Jack Kleinhardt

OTHERS PRESENT

Clerk & Register of Deeds Lori Mott, Administrator Lori Phelps and members of the public

APPROVAL OF AGENDA

There was no approval of the agenda

JUSTICE

1. Medical Examiner
   Ms. Lisa Kaspriak of Mid Michigan Medical Examiner Group gave the 2023 Annual Report, which included on manner of death by month and year, natural deaths, suicides and drug overdoses. The Medical Examiner's office has seen a 250% increase in unclaimed/abandoned bodies in 2023 (14 unclaimed bodies).

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION

1. Bond Discussion
   Road Commission, Members of the Public and Bond Counsel
   There was a question regarding what was approved at the last meeting. Eric McGlothlin of Dickenson Wright Bond Counsel explained to the Board of Commissioners that what they approved at the last meeting was simply a Resolution for Notice (publication) of Intent to Issue Bonds.

   Al Demarest, resident of Clare for 78 years a concerned taxpayer explained he was not criticizing the way the Commissioners Manage the funds of Clare County from their chairs, he only wanted to express his opinion. Mr. Demarest believes that the Commissioners passed resolutions and conceptually approved road commission project. Mr. Demarest feels that this issue needs to be taken to the people in the form of a referendum. He explained that a $12 million loan at 4.36% (30 year amortization) would end with payment of in excess of $10 million in interest, $730,000.00 each year in payments and will be the #1 item budgeted for each year.

   Dewayne Rogers, Road Commission Manager indicated that he has been allocating over a million dollars a year for maintenance on the failing building and will be able to sustain the payment required for this bond. They have been replacing equipment and have a rotation plan now and will not be required to replace 6 pieces of equipment at a time as has been needed in the recent past. There are currently 18 trucks and the plan will replace 1 truck a year with the new rotation plan.

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION - continued

1. Bond Discussion – continued

   Having a new facility and being able to store, wash and maintain the equipment properly will make the equipment last longer.

   Mr. McGlothlin explained risk and liability for Clare County – The County makes a legal pledged security to bond holders and the bonds would be paid out of the MTF revenues (MTF is the gas tax, license and registration fees paid to Road Commissions) – This form of budgeting debt services out of monies received has been broadly used throughout municipalities for many years.

   Manager Rogers answered the question "Could the Road Commission wait 5-years and save money toward the building" – No, repair costs for the failing building will increase as the years pass along with the increase in the cost of building.

   It was explained that the current facility is not ADA compliant, the women have to use the men's bathroom with the men. The new building will resolve these issues and provide front office, a meeting room, new shop facility for mechanics which includes a wash bay that they don't have now, a larger mechanic bay for larger trucks, a parking garage that will accommodate all vehicles. It will not include new office furniture, they will continue to use the same desks, chairs and filing cabinets they currently use.

   Treasurer Beemer-Fritzinger stated that she has managed the road commission funds for the past 16 years and confirmed that they stay within their budget and have a great healthy fund balance. Treasurer Beemer-Fritzinger feels comfortable the Road Commission will be able to make the required payments on this proposed bond.

   Manager Rogers confirmed that every time each of us fill up gas tanks or register our car, we are paying on a bond for Isabella County Road Commission and a $65 million bond for Kalamazoo County. The money each of us spends is not specific to Clare County just because we spend it in Clare County.

PUBLIC COMMENT

Dan Dysinger, Grant Township Supervisor is in favor of a millage to the taxpayers. He believes the Road Commission will just need to educate the public and believes that this long term indebtedness is disastrous.

Pat Adams confirmed he has been to many Clare County Road Commission meetings to hear the discussion and no one likes to pay interest, but there are safety concerns and non-ADA compliant issues, this is not 100% a money issue. A new building is a necessity and should not be put off for extended time.

Meeting Adjourned at 10:12 a.m.

Lori Mott, Clerk
Clare County Board of Commissioners

Jeff Haskell, Chairman
Clare County Board of Commissioners